Activity 6 — Rewriting the Refund Email — E-Commerce Support Inbox

Topic	6 — Customer Service via Email and Chat
Mapping	LO1 · Apply netiquette and the five-part email structure; choose email vs chat correctly.
Format	Case Study + Practical Writing
Duration	15 minutes
Roles	Individually, then compare in pairs.

The Scenario

A Singapore online fashion retailer. Ms Priya ordered a dress for her sister's wedding on 2 August, paid S$189, and received the wrong size. She returned it on 8 August using the prepaid label. It is now 22 August, no refund has appeared, and the wedding is on 30 August. She has emailed twice.

The agent's reply, sent as-is:

Subject: RE: RE: FW: order

Dear Customer,
As per our T&C section 7.3 refunds are processed within 14-21 WORKING DAYS from receipt at our warehouse NOT from when you posted it. Your return was received 14/8. Therefore your refund is NOT late and there is nothing further we can do at this time. Please do not email again as it does not speed up the process.
Regards,
Support Team

Every fact in that email is correct. It is still a service failure.

What You Will Produce

A rewritten email following the five-part structure, plus a channel-choice justification.

Materials: Email structure template · Netiquette checklist.

Discussion Questions

1. List every netiquette failure in the agent's email. There are at least seven.
2. Every fact in the email is accurate. Explain how an email can be 100% correct and still be a service failure.
3. What is the customer's REAL deadline, and does the agent's reply acknowledge it at all?

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4. Rewrite the email using the five-part structure: greeting → acknowledge → solution → next steps → sign-off.

5. 'Please do not email again.' What does this sentence do to the relationship, and what should replace it?

6. Should this have been email, live chat or a phone call? Justify your choice against the channel-selection rule.

Step-by-Step

1. Read the agent's email once at normal speed, then a second time slowly with the netiquette checklist beside you.

2. Mark every failure directly on the email text. Aim for at least seven. Compare with your partner — most people miss the unsigned 'Support Team' and the dead subject line.

3. In one sentence, write what the agent got RIGHT. There is something: the facts and the policy citation are accurate. This matters, because it shows accuracy is not the same as service.

4. Write down the customer's real deadline (30 August, the wedding) and check whether it appears anywhere in the agent's reply. It does not. That absence is the core failure.

5. Now rewrite. Part 1 — greeting: use her name. Part 2 — acknowledge: name the wait, the two prior emails and the wedding, and apologise for the experience without disputing the policy.

6. Part 3 — the solution: state the actual refund date as a calendar date, not 'within 14–21 working days'. Add one concrete action you will take (raise an expedite request, or ship the correct size now against the pending refund).

7. Part 4 — next steps: say exactly what happens next, when, and who does it. Make it clear she does not need to chase.

8. Part 5 — sign-off: your real name, your role, and a direct contact channel. Never 'Support Team'.

9. Fix the subject line last: make it specific and action-oriented, e.g. 'Your refund for order #48213 — resolution by 26 August'.

10. Swap with your partner. Score their rewrite against the netiquette checklist and confirm all five parts are present and the wedding date is acknowledged.

11. Finally, write two lines justifying the channel you would have used, referencing complexity, urgency, emotion and the need for a record.

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Debrief — What a Strong Answer Looks Like

- Netiquette failures to find: 'RE: RE: FW: order' subject line, 'Dear Customer' not her name, ALL CAPS as shouting, policy-section jargon (T&C 7.3), no apology or acknowledgement, an instruction not to make contact, an unsigned 'Support Team' with no individual name, and no next step the customer can act on.
- Correct-but-failing is the key lesson: the agent answered the question the customer TYPED and ignored the question she MEANT — 'will I have this sorted before the wedding on the 30th?'
- The wedding date is the real deadline and the email never mentions it. This is the same 'said vs needed' distinction from Activity 3, in writing.
- A good rewrite names Priya, acknowledges two prior emails and the wedding, states the refund date with a specific day, offers something concrete (expedite request, or a replacement in the right size shipped now), and gives a named person and direct contact.
- 'Please do not email again' tells the customer her only channel is closed. Replace with proactive ownership: 'You don't need to chase this — I'll email you the moment it clears, and here's my direct line.'
- Channel: email is right for the RECORD (money, dates, policy), but this case needed a phone call first because it is time-critical and emotional. Best practice is call, then confirm in writing — using both channels for what each does well.

Check Your Work

Your rewrite has all five parts, names the customer, acknowledges the 30 August wedding, gives a calendar date rather than a working-day range, and is signed by a named person.

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